

TWELVE CASES

Ally Quinn is a true crime podcaster in Havenbay, a coastal city. One of these will be the first episode of the game. They are all murders. None of them is gory.

What I'd love from you: read them in any order, and mark the ones you'd want to hear the rest of. Then the ones you'd skip. Questions at the end. Gut reaction is the useful thing, not the considered one. Don't be careful.

One

Thirty years ago a young woman went into the harbour at the ferry steps. She washed up four days later, three kilometres up the reach, and a man went to prison for it largely because of where she was found. Here is the thing about tides that nobody told the jury: move the time she entered the water by half an hour, and she comes ashore kilometres from where she did. Half an hour is the whole margin. The man they convicted has four months left to live. He has never once said he did it, which is not the same as being innocent. But somebody has been walking around this city for thirty years knowing exactly which half hour it was.

Two

A cleaner empties a bin at the wharf offices and finds two versions of the same page. Same night, same boat. One of them has a man on board. The other one doesn't. He drowned in March, and his mother has the second version framed on her wall, because it is the last document in the world with her son's name on it. There is no conspiracy here. There is a fight on a deck at two in the morning, four frightened men, and a form. And there is a boat that transmits its own position to receivers the company doesn't own.

Three

The file number is the only name she has. A woman was found under the viaduct last November and the record says: unidentified female, thirty to forty-five, no fixed address, death by misadventure. Three of those five things are wrong. She had an address. She had a job. And she has a mother interstate who is still ringing a phone that stopped being answered in November, telling herself her daughter is angry with her. The man who killed her did one cheap thing and one clever thing. The cheap thing was taking her bag. The clever thing was choosing where to leave her, because he knew exactly what this city writes down when it finds a woman under a bridge.

Four

A woman in her sixties dies in a kitchen fire and everyone believes the chip pan, because the fire says chip pan and because of what everyone already thought of her. Her daughter is starting to believe it too. But the smoke alarm didn't fall in the heat. It was taken down, the battery pulled, and put back on its bracket the wrong way round, by a man working in the dark who was six years behind on things he couldn't afford an inspector to see. Two families are asleep under his other alarms tonight.

Five

He photographed a tally sheet at ten past eleven and he was dead by midnight. Heart attack, they said, and he was fifty-eight and carrying too much weight and under obvious strain, so nobody asked twice. The strike

ballot was declared lost by fourteen votes. Four hundred people signed away half their redundancy eleven days later. And the twenty-six-year-old who counted those votes has been quietly told she miscounted, and she has started to believe that too.

Six

An invoice for work on a boat that sank. The work was never done. The harbour pilot who drowned when his launch hit a pylon had been on shift eleven hours, so pilot error was easy to believe, and his widow's payout is refused for exactly as long as that finding stands. She is three months from losing the house. Here is what makes it unbearable: nobody meant to kill him. A man skipped a job and billed for it, as he had forty times before, and this was the time it killed someone. Three other boats went out this week on the same servicing.

Seven

Fifteen years ago a fire in a foundry office killed the night storeman and the cause was recorded as undetermined, which is a real finding and not a euphemism, and which has functioned ever since as nobody's fault. The insurer sent its own investigator. He wrote a second report saying the fire began somewhere the first report had ruled out. That report was never filed, because the claim settled first. The storeman's brother is sixty-nine. He has been refused a death benefit every year since 2011, because undetermined isn't something you can be compensated for.

Eight

Two deaths at the same address in Highcliff, eleven years apart. Both certified natural. Both by the same doctor. The house passed twice, and both times to the same man, who is the doctor's brother-in-law. The doctor is not a killer and has never taken a penny. He is a man who signed for two deaths he didn't look at closely, because he was asked to by a family he liked, as he has done a dozen times for people who were kind to him. There is a third person living at that address now. She is eighty-one, and her will changed four months ago.

Nine

She died in a boarding house in 2013 and they called it misadventure. Her samples were destroyed in 2020, exactly on schedule, correctly, because nobody asked for them to be kept. The only person who wanted the case reopened was her son, who was nineteen and in care and didn't know that asking was a thing a person could do. He is thirty-two now and has spent his whole adult life inside that one word. What survives is the handling record: eleven days in 2014 when the samples were signed out and returned, by someone who left the reason blank. The man who manages that boarding house still manages it, and still decides who gets a room.

Ten

A man has served sixteen years for killing his business partner in a warehouse fire. The case turned on a fire investigator explaining pour patterns and crazed glass to a jury, and both of those techniques have since been abandoned by the people who used to swear by them. The fire was electrical, in a switchboard the landlord had been warned about twice. His partner died because he went back inside for a laptop. And the worst part is this: nobody in that courtroom did anything wrong. The science was simply wrong, and everyone was honest, and a man lost sixteen years.

Eleven

A witness named a face he saw from the viaduct walkway, two hundred metres away, at nine minutes past six on a November evening. The harbour's own record for that hour says the fog had closed visibility to under a hundred metres, which is why two ferries were cancelled that night, which is in a public register anyone could have read. Nobody at the trial asked what the witness could actually see. She has served eleven years. Her son is nineteen. He has lived since he was eight in the care of his uncle, who did it.

Twelve

Eight years, built on a printed time. The corner shop's till ran nine minutes fast and had done for months, which the owner knew, because he corrected it by hand in a reconciliation book every single night. Nine minutes moves a man from two streets away from a killing to sitting inside a bus that runs to a timetable. Nobody checked the clock, because printed times look like facts. The shop closed in 2022 and the reconciliation books are in a box in the owner's daughter's garage, which floods.

Questions

1. **Which one do you most want to hear the rest of?** First instinct, not your considered view.
2. **Which one would you not bother with?**
3. **For your pick: what did it?** A line, an image, a person, a question you wanted answered.
4. **Was there one you didn't believe?** That's as useful as the ones you liked.
5. **Would you come back tomorrow for another episode of the one you chose?**

Thank you. Honest and blunt is worth more than kind.